The ‘discovery’ not of the McMahon Line as such, but of the ambiguity of some of its parts, should be credited not to Caroe, but to the British botanist and explorer Frank Kingdon-Ward, who made it to Monyul, or the Tawang area, in 1934–5. He noted that the Indian government had for a long time

> been paying an annual subsidy to the de facto rulers of Monyul (Tawang) under the impression that they were independent chiefs. Possibly they were at the beginning. But it has lately come to light that most of the subsidy went into the purses of the power at Tsona-Dzong (in Tibet) and hence to Lhasa…this practice dilutes the Indian claim to Monyul…a deal was effected in 1914; Monyul was to become part of the Balipara Frontier Tract.[77]

Kingdon-Ward held the Indian government responsible for this neglect. ‘Had India been able to take up possession in 1914 no more could have been heard about the matter.’[78] Kingdon-Ward had a solution to the problem: ‘effective occupation by 1939 or at the latest 1940’.[79] But World War II came in between, and it was not until the early 1950s that Tawang was eventually brought under the control of the central Indian government.

Kingdon-Ward’s foray into Tawang caused some problems in relations between British India and Tibet. He was arrested by the local authorities, and the Tibetans protested to the British officer Derrick Williamson, then on a tour to Lhasa. After some negotiations with the Tibetans, Kingdon-Ward was sent back to the lowlands. It was after this incident that Olaf Caroe decided to make the Shimla agreements available to a wider public. Until then, they were known only to a limited number of frontier officials.[80]

Despite the Kingdon-Ward incident, relations between Tibet and the British in India remained cordial throughout the 1920s and the 1930s. Younghusband’s foray into Tibet in 1903–4, the flight of the Dalai Lama, and the brutal humiliation of the Tibetans, were forgotten. In 1922, Laden La (the Bhutia Sikkimese officer, who had taken part in Younghusband’s ‘expedition’ and later been an interpreter at the Shimla Conference) was sent by the British to Lhasa to establish a Tibetan police force. His efforts were extremely successful, and Colonel Frederick Bailey, a British intelligence officer, was able to report from a visit to Lhasa in 1924 that, ‘Sardar Bahadur Laden La has organised a very credible police force for Lhasa city. The men are smart and dressed in thick khaki serge in winter, and blue with yellow piping in summer.’[81] Led by Laden La, the Tibetan